LEGACY OF THE DRAGON

Ip Man's Journey with Wing Chun

Volume One

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《龙的遗产：叶问与咏春的旅程》

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First Edition

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DEDICATION

> *To the grandmasters who carried the flame across oceans and generations — and to every student who keeps the art alive through daily practice.*

Introduction

Wing Chun is not merely a fighting system — it is a philosophy, a way of moving through the world with economy, intention, and precision. Ip Man embodied these values not only in the training hall but in every dimension of his life. To understand his art is to understand the man; to understand the man is to understand why Wing Chun continues to resonate across continents and generations.

This book chronicles Ip Man's journey from his humble beginnings in Foshan, Guangdong Province, through the transfer of Wing Chun to Hong Kong, and to his enduring global legacy. Through an in-depth analysis of training methods, diet, philosophy, and personal relationships, this volume provides a comprehensive portrait of the man who irrevocably enriched the world of martial arts.

Each chapter concludes with traditional Chinese song lyrics — original compositions that carry the emotional spirit of the culture, era, and individual it honours. The lyrics appear in Chinese with full English translation so that every reader may share in their meaning.

Whether you are a seasoned practitioner, a student of history, or simply curious about the roots of one of the world's most influential martial arts traditions, these pages invite you into a story as timeless as the techniques it describes.

May these words honour the memory of a master, and may they inspire all who read them to pursue excellence, discipline, and wisdom — wherever their own journey may lead.

Chapter One: The Life and Passing of Ip Man

Early Life and Beginnings

Ip Man, born Ip Kai-man on 1 October 1893 in Foshan, Guangdong Province, China, was the third of four children born to Ip Oi-dor and Ng Shui. He grew up in a wealthy, cultured family and received a traditional Chinese education alongside his siblings. His early environment instilled in him a discipline and sense of refinement that would define his character throughout his life.

Between the ages of nine and thirteen — historical accounts differ on the precise age — Ip Man became a student of Chan Wah-shun, a prominent Wing Chun master and disciple of the legendary Leung Jan. Chan was already in his late fifties when he accepted Ip Man as his sixteenth and final student. Due to his advancing age, Chan could train Ip Man for only a few years before suffering a mild stroke and retiring. Ip Man's training was then continued under Chan's senior student, Ng Chung-sok.

At fifteen, Ip Man travelled to Hong Kong to attend St. Stephen's College. There he encountered Leung Bik, the son of Leung Jan — his own master's master. After an initially humbling encounter in which Leung Bik effortlessly defeated him, Ip Man trained intensively under him for several years, completing his mastery of Wing Chun.

Professional Journey

Ip Man returned to Foshan at the age of twenty-four. He served as a police officer for the Nationalist government and gave private Wing Chun lessons to subordinates, friends, and relatives — though he did not formally open a school. During the Japanese occupation of China, he remained loyal to his country and refused all overtures to collaborate with the occupying forces, continuing to teach discreetly throughout.

The decisive turn came in late 1949, when the Communist Party secured control of mainland China. As a former officer of the Kuomintang government, Ip Man was compelled to flee — without his family — to Hong Kong. He arrived with little money and no established network. In 1950, through the introduction of a fellow villager, he opened his first Wing Chun class at the Restaurant Workers' Association in Sham Shui Po.

Early days were difficult. Students came and went, money was scarce, and he moved his school twice. But his reputation grew steadily, carried by the victories of his students in challenge matches — contests he actively encouraged as the truest test of martial skill. Among those students were Bruce Lee, Wong Shun Leung, Leung Sheung, Chu Shong Tin, and his own sons Ip Chun and Ip Ching.

Personal Life and Family

Ip Man married Cheung Wing-sing in Foshan. Together they had four children: sons Ip Chun and Ip Ching, and daughters Ip Nga-sum and Ip Nga-wun. When Ip Man fled to Hong Kong in 1949, his family remained behind in Foshan. His wife Cheung Wing-sing passed away alone in Foshan in 1960, separated from her husband by the closed borders

between mainland China and Hong Kong. Ip Man was never able to return to say goodbye. His sons Ip Chun and Ip Ching eventually made their way to Hong Kong in 1962.

Death and Legacy

Ip Man's health began to decline in the late 1960s. He was diagnosed with laryngeal cancer. Approximately six weeks before his death, he asked his two sons and his student Lau Hon Lam to film him performing the complete Wing Chun system — a final act of stewardship to preserve the art for future generations. He passed away on 2 December 1972 in Hong Kong, aged seventy-nine.

His legacy has grown with every passing decade. The Wing Chun system he refined and transmitted continues to be practised and respected worldwide, ensuring his legacy endures for generations to come.

♪『The Legend of Ip Man』

Instrumentation: GuZheng (古筝) · Erhu (二胡) · Pipa (琵琶) · Chinese Drums

一代宗师，威风凛凛

A grandmaster of an era, commanding and awe-inspiring

拳术无敌，武艺超群

His fists unmatched, his martial skill beyond compare

风雨中的身影，依旧坚定

Through storm and rain, his silhouette stands firm

他的传奇，永不磨灭

His legend — never to be erased

步伐轻盈，拳影如风

His footwork light, his strikes swift as the wind

每一招每一式，都深藏智慧

Each technique, each form — wisdom folded within

在武道的殿堂，永远闪耀光芒

In the halls of martial arts, forever shining bright

Music style: Traditional Chinese — melodic, stately, meditative

Chapter Two: The Training Regimen and Dietary Habits

Daily Training Routine

Ip Man's training regimen was a model of disciplined consistency. His daily practice centred on Wing Chun's three foundational forms — Siu Nim Tao, Chum Kiu, and Biu Jee — each practised with deliberate attention to structure, alignment, and intention. For Ip Man, the form was never mechanical repetition; it was a living dialogue between body and principle.

Chi Sau (sticky hands) training formed another cornerstone of his daily practice. Through sustained partner drilling, he developed a sensitivity to incoming force that allowed him to respond fluidly and instinctively. His students frequently described his touch as simultaneously soft and immovable — an embodiment of Wing Chun's central paradox.

Wooden dummy training completed his daily regimen. Working the Muk Yan Chong with precision and power, he refined his timing, coordination, and the practical application of the system's more advanced techniques. He trained consistently throughout his life, adapting his practice to his physical condition as he aged — a testament to the art's adaptability and to his own lifelong commitment.

Diet and Nutrition

Ip Man's dietary philosophy aligned closely with traditional Chinese medicine: balance, moderation, and the harmonisation of internal energies. His meals favoured steamed fish, rice, fresh vegetables, and medicinal soups long associated with longevity and internal strength. He was notably moderate in his habits, understanding that physical excellence required as much attention at the table as in the training hall.

He was known to emphasise that a martial artist's body is a living instrument — one that demands respect, rest, and proper nourishment if it is to remain sharp and resilient across a lifetime of practice. This holistic view of the practitioner's body as an integrated system of mind, spirit, and flesh was central to his entire approach.

♪『Discipline and Devotion』

Instrumentation: Pipa (琵琶) · Erhu (二胡) · GuZheng (古筝) · Chinese Drums

每日操练，汗水如雨

Daily practice — sweat falling like rain

身心合一，方得真道

Body and mind as one — only then the true path reveals itself

晨起习武，日落不辞

Rising at dawn to train, refusing to stop at dusk

功夫之道，贵在坚持

The way of kung fu — its treasure is perseverance

饮食有节，心清气正

Moderate in eating, clear in mind, upright in spirit

内外兼修，武者之本

Cultivating both inside and out — the root of the martial practitioner

Music style: Traditional Chinese — rhythmic, expressive, emotionally resonant

Chapter Three: The Notable Students of Ip Man

The measure of any master lies not only in the depth of his own skill but in the quality of those he shapes. By this measure, Ip Man stands among the most consequential teachers in the history of martial arts. His students became masters in their own right — each interpreting and extending his teachings in ways that collectively ensured Wing Chun's global survival.

Bruce Lee

Perhaps the most celebrated of Ip Man's disciples, Bruce Lee studied Wing Chun in Hong Kong in the 1950s. He transformed Wing Chun's principles into the philosophical and technical foundation of his own revolutionary system, Jeet Kune Do. His global celebrity brought unprecedented attention to Chinese martial arts and immortalised Ip Man's teachings in the popular imagination.

Wong Shun Leung

Known throughout Hong Kong as the "King of Talking Hands," Wong Shun Leung established Wing Chun's practical credibility through numerous challenge matches in the 1950s and 1960s. His victories earned a reputation that drew serious students from across the martial arts world.

Leung Sheung

One of Ip Man's first and most senior Hong Kong students, Leung Sheung was known for his deep and faithful understanding of the original teachings. He became a revered teacher and played a vital role in preserving the integrity of the system during its formative years.

Chu Shong Tin

Often called the "King of Siu Nim Tao," Chu Shong Tin distinguished himself through his extraordinary mastery of Wing Chun's foundational form. His insights into the internal mechanics of the art contributed significantly to its understanding worldwide.

Leung Ting

Leung Ting founded the international WingTsun organisation, one of the most widely distributed Wing Chun lineages globally. He wrote extensively on the art and played a central role in its global spread through structured curricula and international associations.

Ip Chun and Ip Ching

Ip Man's elder son Ip Chun and younger son Ip Ching dedicated their lives to preserving and promoting their father's legacy. Both became respected teachers who instructed students in Hong Kong and at international seminars for decades. They represent the most direct living link to Ip Man's original system.

William Cheung and Hawkins Cheung

William Cheung contributed extensively to the documentation and global dissemination of Wing Chun through teaching and writing. Hawkins Cheung played a pioneering role in popularising Wing Chun across North America, adapting its transmission to Western students while maintaining fidelity to Ip Man's core principles.

♪『The Legacy Lives On』

Instrumentation: Dizi (笛子) · Erhu (二胡) · GuZheng (古筝) · Chinese Drums

传承千年，英雄之道

A lineage of a thousand years — the way of heroes

每一招每一式，都蕴含智慧

Every technique, every form — wisdom held within

师父的教诺，铭刻心间

The master's teachings engraved upon the heart

他的徒弟们，继续发扬光大

His disciples — carrying the light forward and outward

师父的精神，永远与我们同在

The master's spirit — forever with us

Music style: Traditional Chinese — lyrical, narrative, generational

Chapter Four: The Influence of Ip Man on Modern Wing Chun

Ip Man's influence on modern Wing Chun is both profound and pervasive. He is credited with standardising the system's curriculum at a critical historical moment — ensuring that its core techniques and philosophical principles would be transmitted coherently across generations and around the world.

His emphasis on scientific efficiency — using the least effort to achieve the greatest effect — was ahead of its time. Modern practitioners and sports scientists have recognised in Wing Chun's structure a biomechanical sophistication that justifies its enduring relevance in an era of rapidly evolving combat sports.

Beyond technique, Ip Man modelled a particular character: modest in bearing yet unwavering in principle, welcoming students regardless of background at a time when such openness was by no means the norm in Chinese martial arts culture. This ethos — that Wing Chun belongs to anyone committed enough to learn it — continues to define the art's culture worldwide.

His influence can be seen in modern mixed martial arts, in self-defence curricula worldwide, and in the billions of people who have encountered Chinese martial arts through the films of Bruce Lee and the subsequent Ip Man movie franchise. The ripples of a single teacher's life, it turns out, can reach very far indeed.

♪『The Unbroken Thread』

Instrumentation: Pipa (琵琶) · Erhu (二胡) · Yangqin (扬琴) · Chinese Drums

一根枳木主，千枝散天下

One wooden dummy, a thousand branches spread beneath the sky

小念头中，包罗万象

In Siu Nim Tao — all things are contained

师父的手，轻轻一碰

The master's hand — a gentle touch

徧子的心，顿时明了

The student's heart — suddenly understands

咏春传遍，无远弗界

Wing Chun transmitted everywhere, no distance too far

Music style: Traditional Chinese with a fusion of modern rhythms

Chapter Five: Ip Man's Personal Life and Legacy

Marriage and Family

Ip Man married Cheung Wing-sing in Foshan. She was a steadfast and devoted partner throughout the years of political upheaval and financial uncertainty. Together they had four children: sons Ip Chun and Ip Ching, and daughters Ip Nga-sum and Ip Nga-wun. When Ip Man fled to Hong Kong in 1949, his family remained in Foshan. His wife passed away alone from cancer in 1960, separated from her husband by the closed border. Ip Man was unable to attend her funeral or say goodbye — a grief he carried for the rest of his life.

Character and Personal Qualities

Those who knew Ip Man personally consistently described a man of quiet authority, refined manners, and deep personal warmth. He was unhurried in speech, precise in movement, and unfailingly generous in instruction. He did not distinguish between wealthy and poor students, nor between Chinese and foreign ones — a remarkable openness in the martial arts culture of his time. His student Wong Shun Leung once described sparring with him as "trying to catch smoke."

Later Years

In the 1960s, Ip Man's growing fame attracted wealthier and better-educated students to his school. In 1967, he and several of his senior students established the Hong Kong Ving Tsun Athletic Association, formalising the organisation of his lineage. In his final years, despite declining health from laryngeal cancer, he continued to teach and receive visitors from across the martial arts world. He passed away on 2 December 1972, aged seventy-nine.

♪『Legacy of a Master』

Instrumentation: Sheng (笙) · Pipa (琵琶) · Erhu (二胡) · Yangqin (扬琴)

大师的风范，永存心间

The bearing of the master — living permanently in the heart

他教会我们勇敢，教会我们坚韧

He taught us courage; he taught us resilience

他的遗产，如星辰般闪耀

His legacy — shining like stars

无论未来多远，他的精神常在

However distant the future, his spirit remains

大师的传承，代代相传

The master's inheritance — passed generation to generation

Music style: Traditional Chinese classical with modern rhythm fusion

Chapter Six: Wing Chun Organisations and Their Global Impact

The global spread of Wing Chun was made possible through the sustained, organised efforts of associations founded by Ip Man's students and their successors — each dedicated to standardising curricula, training instructors, and connecting practitioners across borders.

Key International Organisations

- International Wing Chun Martial Art Association (IWCMMA) — Founded by Leung Ting; focuses on standardising Wing Chun technique internationally and organising global seminars and certification programmes.
- Wing Chun United Kingdom (WCUK) — Instrumental in introducing Wing Chun to Europe; organises training events and connects practitioners continent-wide.
- American Wing Chun Kung Fu Association (AWCKFA) — Pioneered the spread of Wing Chun across North America through training camps and instructor certification.
- Australian Wing Chun Federation (AWCF) — Promotes the art throughout the Pacific region through structured training and community development.
- European Wing Chun Organisation (EWCO) — Unifies practitioners across Europe, offering a platform for exchange, collaboration, and competitive development.
- Hong Kong Ving Tsun Athletic Association (HKVTAA) — Founded by Ip Man himself in 1967; the original formal institution of his lineage.
- Canadian Wing Chun Association (CWCA) — Promotes Wing Chun across Canada through training, events, and instructor certification.

Together, these organisations have ensured that Wing Chun remains a living, evolving martial art — accessible to new practitioners worldwide while remaining anchored in the principles Ip Man spent his life refining.

♪『The World Listens』

Instrumentation: Xiao (笙) · Pipa (琵琶) · Erhu (二胡) · Chinese Drums

咏春传遍，六大洲际

Wing Chun transmitted across six continents

天南地北，尽是师门徜子

From south to north, students of the same school everywhere

传承不息，光耀当代

The lineage without ceasing, shining in our age

咏春之光，照耀全球

The light of Wing Chun — illuminating the whole world

Music style: Traditional Chinese — expansive, inspiring, global in feeling

Chapter Seven: The Techniques and Philosophy of Wing Chun

Core Techniques

- Siu Nim Tao (小念头 — Small Idea Form): The foundational form. Develops correct posture, relaxation, and the fundamental hand techniques from which the entire system flows.
- Chum Kiu (寻桥 — Seeking the Bridge): Introduces footwork, body turning, and the bridging of distance between practitioners.
- Biu Jee (镖指 — Thrusting Fingers): Emergency recovery techniques and powerful strikes for compromised positions.
- Muk Yan Chong (木人桩 — Wooden Dummy Form): Develops precision, timing, and the practical application of all preceding forms.
- Luk Dim Boon Kwan (六点半棍 — Six-and-a-Half Point Pole): The long-pole form, developing full-body power and coordination at range.
- Baat Cham Dao (八斩刀 — Eight Slash Knives): The butterfly sword form — the most advanced weapons training in the system.
- Chi Sau (粘手 — Sticky Hands): The art's signature partner drill; cultivates sensitivity, reflexes, and the ability to sense and redirect an opponent's force.

Guiding Principles

- Simplicity and Economy of Motion — Every movement must serve a direct purpose. Ornamentation is the enemy of efficiency.
- Centreline Theory — Control of the central axis between two practitioners determines control of the entire exchange.
- Simultaneous Attack and Defence — The practitioner does not wait to defend before attacking; both occur in the same movement.
- Relaxation Under Pressure — Tension dissipates power. The practitioner who remains relaxed moves faster and hits harder.
- Use of the Opponent's Force — Wing Chun redirects incoming force rather than meeting it head-on, turning the attacker's energy against them.
- Adaptability — Wing Chun does not impose a fixed response. It meets the situation as it is, not as one might wish it to be.
- Mental Discipline — Technical skill divorced from a clear, calm mind is unreliable. Mental cultivation is as essential as physical technique.

♪『Master's Path』

Instrumentation: Sanxian (三弦) · GuZheng (古筝) · Erhu (二胡) · Pipa (琵琶)

大师的道路，智慧的源泉

The master's path — a source of wisdom

每一步都深藏着真理

Every step concealing truth within it

从心开始，直达目标

Beginning from the heart, arriving at the target directly

在训练中，他的理念明亮

In training, his philosophy shines clearly

大师的道路，指引前行

The master's path guides the way ahead

Music style: Traditional Chinese — philosophical, meditative, melodically rich

Chapter Eight: Legacy and Influence of Ip Man's Disciples

The disciples Ip Man cultivated did not merely replicate his system — they carried it into new contexts, new countries, and new generations, each adding their own chapter to a story that began in Foshan and has since encircled the world.

Bruce Lee — The Global Ambassador

Bruce Lee's transformation of Wing Chun principles into Jeet Kune Do, and his subsequent global stardom, made Ip Man's teachings the most widely known martial arts lineage on earth. His films introduced hundreds of millions to Chinese martial arts and created an enduring cultural bridge between East and West.

Wong Shun Leung — The Proof of Combat

Wong Shun Leung's fearless participation in challenge matches across Hong Kong demonstrated Wing Chun's practical effectiveness in real conditions. His victories gave Ip Man's school credibility and attracted a wave of serious students throughout the 1950s and 1960s.

Leung Ting — The Organiser

Leung Ting founded the WingTsun organisation, one of the most formally structured and widely distributed Wing Chun lineages globally. His systematic approach to curriculum and instructor certification enabled Wing Chun to scale its transmission across dozens of countries with consistent quality.

Ip Chun and Ip Ching — The Custodians

As Ip Man's sons, Ip Chun and Ip Ching bear the most direct responsibility for the stewardship of his legacy. Both taught Wing Chun in Hong Kong for decades and participated in international seminars, ensuring the most direct lineage remained accessible to students worldwide.

William Cheung and Lok Yiu

William Cheung contributed extensively to the documentation of Wing Chun through writing and teaching, making the system accessible to Western practitioners. Lok Yiu, one of Ip Man's earliest Foshan students, was renowned for his mastery of wooden dummy technique and his role in preserving the Foshan-period lineage.

Hawkins Cheung — The Bridge to America

Hawkins Cheung was instrumental in establishing Wing Chun's presence in North America. His deep knowledge of the art and ability to adapt its transmission to Western students made him one of the most respected figures in the international Wing Chun community.

♪『Eternal Lineage』

Instrumentation: Guqin (古琴) · Erhu (二胡) · GuZheng (古筝) · Chinese Drums

万事如意，咏春不息

May all things be well — Wing Chun never ceasing

弟子遍天下，传承永不止

Disciples filling the world, the lineage endures without end

世代相传，誓为咏春护航

Generation to generation — a vow to guard and guide Wing Chun

Music style: Traditional Chinese — slow, meditative, enduring legacy

Conclusion

As we have seen throughout this exploration, Wing Chun has not merely preserved its rich history — it has evolved to meet the demands of martial arts practice in every era and on every continent. Ip Man's legacy continues to thrive through his disciples, who have carried the torch to every corner of the globe.

What began as one man's commitment to a centuries-old tradition in Foshan has become a living global community of practitioners united by shared principles: economy of motion, clarity of purpose, and respect for the lineage that connects every student to every master who came before them.

> *万事如意，咏春不息，弟子遍天下，传承永不止。"May all things be well — Wing Chun never ceasing, disciples filling the world, the lineage endures without end."*

The story of Ip Man is the story of what one life, lived with discipline and integrity, can set in motion. His art endures not in museums or archives, but in the hands and minds of millions of living practitioners who, every day, reach across time toward a grandmaster they never met, but whose touch they can still feel.

Preview: Volume Two

Volume Two will go deeper — into the personal journeys of Ip Man's disciples, the challenges they faced in establishing Wing Chun abroad, and the unique interpretations each brought to his system. Stay tuned as we continue our journey into the world of Wing Chun.

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